FOREST SURVEY

FADING GREENS OF INDIA

By **JUMANA SHAH**

The 18th biennial India State of Forest Report 2023, released recently by the Forest Survey of India, has revealed sobering details at several levels. The concerns relate to both the extent and the nature of our green cover. Firstly, the report states 25.17 per cent of India's land mass is covered by forests. This already falls woefully short of the global benchmark of 33 per cent. Of this, only 21.76 per cent constitutes forested areas, with the remaining 3.41 per cent categorised as tree cover. On degraded forests, the report states that dense and moderately dense forests—both within and outside reserved forest areas—are being replaced by industrial and urban clusters and subsequently being compensated for with commercial plantations. Although the survey reports an overall increase in forest and tree cover, the data has come under severe criticism from experts. They point out that plantations such as bamboo, rubber and mango orchards have been counted as forest, creating a smokescreen of healthy green coverage. These seasonally harvested plantations do not replicate the biological diversity or ecological benefits of natural forests. This month, the Supreme Court mandated the Centre and states to refrain from cutting any forest for development, unless compensatory land is provided for afforestation. ■

Source: ISFR 2023

NATIONAL FOREST COVER*

2023	2013	INCREASE
715,343 sq. km	698,712 sq. km	16,630 sq. km
		↑2.4%

25%
THE SHARE OF FORESTS IN THE COUNTRY'S LAND MASS—FAR SHORT OF THE GLOBAL BENCHMARK OF 33%

**All lands, more than or equal to one hectare, with a tree canopy of more than or equal to 10%; figures show decadal change*

VERY DENSE FOREST

2023	2013	INCREASE
102,502 sq. km	83,502 sq. km	19,000 sq. km
		↑22.8%

MODERATELY DENSE FOREST

2023	2013	DECREASE
307,673 sq. km	318,745 sq. km	11,072 sq. km
		↓3.5%

OPEN FOREST

2023	2013	INCREASE
305,167 sq. km	295,651 sq. km	9,516 sq. km
		↑3.2%

MANGROVE

2023	2013	INCREASE
4,992 sq. km	4,695 sq. km	296 sq. km
		↑6.3%

WESTERN GHATS ECO-SENSITIVE AREAS

2023	2013	DECREASE
44,044 sq. km	44,102 sq. km	58 sq. km
		↓0.13%

The Western Ghats run across Goa, Gujarat, Karnataka, Kerala, Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu

"The marginal increase in national forest cover masks concerns about regional forest losses, particularly in biodiversity-rich areas. These findings raise urgent concerns about the effectiveness of conservation efforts, policies and priorities"

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